Which Question Goes to Whom?

What to ask Mom, the family and her doctor while you plan ahead, with room to write down what you hear.

Planning ahead leaves a family with a list of open questions and no note of who each one belongs to. Some are Mom's to answer. Some belong to the family. A few are for a professional, at an ordinary appointment, whenever one comes around.

This guide doesn't answer the questions and doesn't say which matters most. They aren't in any order, and there's no date to ask them by. Write what you hear under each one, in the words it was said in.

Mom

These are hers to answer. Ask a few at a time, whenever it comes up naturally, and write down her words.

1. What would you like us to get ready now, while nothing needs to change?

2. What would you rather we left alone for the time being?

3. If something in your days changed, what would you want us to notice, and what would you rather tell us yourself?

4. Who are you happy to have read what we write down?

Your brother, your sister and anyone else who would be part of this

Each person can answer on their own, in person, by phone or by message. Nobody has to answer all of them.

1. Of everything that's been suggested, what do you think is useful to do now?

2. What do you think can wait, and what would you want to know before coming back to it?

3. Is there a piece of the preparation you'd be willing to take?

4. If you couldn't do your piece one month, who would you want to pick it up?

5. How much of this has ended up with one person so far, and does that seem realistic to you?

6. What would make you want to sit down and look at the plan again?

Her doctor

At one of Mom's ordinary appointments, with Mom there or with her say-so. Nothing here calls for a special visit.

1. Here are the questions the family couldn't answer. Which are yours, and who should the others go to?

2. Is there anything in what we've written down that you'd want to look at yourself?

3. Which changes would you want to hear about from us between visits?

A care consultant

Someone who looks at Mom's whole situation with the family, not only the list in front of you.

1. Looking at what we plan to do now and what we're waiting on, what else would you want to know before it's put in order?

2. Which other professionals would you want involved in a plan like ours, and who in the family should ask them?

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer these questions, say which one matters most, or put them in order. Nobody has to ask all fifteen. If Mom would rather not answer one, write “she'd rather not say” under it; that is her answer for now.

Ready for the next step?

You know which questions are Mom's, which are the family's and which to save for a professional. The care interview gives the answers somewhere to go: it walks you through Mom's situation as it is today, area by area, and turns what you tell it into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The questions about what Mom wants and about what each person is willing to take follow what AARP's planning guide and the Family Caregiver Alliance's guide to family meetings suggest families ask. The rest come from the Family Care Roadmap's working list for this step. The grouping by role is ours.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting